

JKBOSE 2026

CLASS 11TH

THE TALE OF MELON CITY

LECTURE-1

ENGLISH

HUSSAIN SIR



Topics To Covered

1 ... Lec. 01. (The Tale of Melon city)

2 ... Detailed explanation.

3 ...

4 ...

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



- **Vikram Seth** (b. 1952) is an Indian novelist and poet best known for works like A Suitable Boy and Beastly Tales from Here and There. His writing often blends wit, satire, and moral questions. The Tale of Melon City is a ^{funny} humorous yet thought-provoking poem from his collection Beastly Tales from Here and There.

The Tale of Melon City



- In the city of which I sing
- There was a just and placid King.
- The King ^{honest} ^{calm} proclaimed an arch should be
- ^{built} ^{to show victory} constructed, that triumphally
- Would span the major thoroughfare
- To edify spectators there.
- The workmen went and built the thing.
- They did so since he was the King.
- The King rode down the thoroughfare
- To edify spectators there.



Just – fair, righteous

Placid – calm, peaceful

Proclaimed – announced officially

Arch – curved structure

Triumphally – in a way that shows success or victory

Thoroughfare – main road

Edify – to educate, improve morally or intellectually

Spectators – people watching

Constructed – built

SUMMARY:

The poet begins by describing a city ruled by a fair (just) and calm (placid) king. The king ordered that a grand arch be built across the main road (thoroughfare) to inspire and educate (edify) the public. The workmen obeyed because he was the king. When the arch was ready, the king rode under it to show it to the people.

The Tale of Melon City

- Under the arch he lost his crown.
- The arch was built too low. A frown
- Appeared upon his placid face.
- The King said, 'This is a disgrace.
- The chief of builders will be hanged.'
- The rope and gallows were arranged.
- The chief of builders was led out.
- He passed the King. He gave a shout,
- 'O King, it was the workmen's fault'
- 'Oh!' said the King, and called a halt ^{to stop}

Frown – expression showing displeasure

Disgrace – shameful act

Chief of builders – head constructor

Hanged – executed by hanging

Gallows – wooden frame used for hanging

Halt – stop

SUMMARY:

As the king rode under the arch, his crown was knocked off because the arch was too low. This made the calm king angry. He called it a disgrace and ordered the chief of builders to be executed (hanged). But the chief blamed the workmen, so the king stopped the execution for the moment.

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- To the proceedings. Being just
- (And placider now) he said, 'I must
- Have all the workmen hanged instead.'
- The workmen looked surprised, and said,
- 'O King, you do not realise
- The bricks were made of the wrong size.'
- 'Summon the masons!' said the King.
- The masons stood there quivering.
- 'It was the architect...', they said,
- The architect was summoned.

Proceedings – events or actions in process

Placider – calmer

Summon – call formally

Masons – people who work with stone or bricks

Quivering – shaking slightly

Architect – person who designs buildings

SUMMARY:

The king decided to punish the workmen instead, but the workmen blamed the masons, saying the bricks were the wrong size. The masons, trembling with fear, blamed the architect. So the king ordered the architect to be brought before him.

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- 'Well, architect,' said His Majesty.
- 'I do ^{order} ordain that you shall be
- Hanged.' Said the architect, 'O King,
- You have forgotten one small thing.
- You made certain ^{changes} amendments to
- The plans when I showed them to you.'
- The King heard this. The King saw red.
- In fact he nearly lost his head;
- But being a just and placid King
- He said, 'This is a ^{complicated} tricky thing.'

His Majesty – respectful title for a

Ordain – order formally

Amendments – changes or corrections

Saw red – became very angry

Tricky – complicated

SUMMARY:

The king told the architect he must be hanged. But the architect reminded the king that it was he (the king) who had changed the design. This made the king very angry, but since he was fair, he admitted it was a complicated matter.

QUESTION



What did the king order to be constructed?

- 1 A palace
- 2 An arch across the main road ~~✗~~
- 3 A market
- 4 A bridge

QUESTION



What happened when the king rode under the arch?

- 1 His crown fell off ✖
- 2 The arch collapsed
- 3 The arch broke
- 4 The people laughed

QUESTION



Who did the chief of builders blame?

1 The masons

2 The king

3 The architect

4 The workmen



QUESTION



Who reminded the king that he had changed the design?

- 1 The chief of builders
- 2 The masons
- 3 The architect 
- 4 The councillor

The Tale of Melon City

- I need some counsel. Bring to me
- The wisest man in this country.'
- The wisest man was found and brought,
- Nay, carried, to the Royal Court.
- He could not walk and could not see,
- So old (and therefore wise) was he —
- But in a quavering voice he said,
- 'The culprit must be punished.
- Truly, the arch it was that banged
- The crown off, and it must be hanged'.

Counsel – advice

Nay – an old word meaning “rather” or “instead”

Quavering – trembling, shaky (voice)

Culprit – person or thing responsible for a wrong doing

Banged – hit forcefully

SUMMARY:

The king decided to seek advice and called for the wisest man in the kingdom. The old man was so feeble he had to be carried. In a shaky voice, he declared that the real culprit was the arch itself because it knocked off the crown. Therefore, the arch should be hanged.

The Tale of Melon City



- To the scaffold the arch was led
- When suddenly a Councillor said —
- ‘How can we hang so shamefully
- What touched your head, Your Majesty?’
- ‘True,’ mused the King. By now the crowd,
- Restless, was muttering aloud.
- The King ~~perceived~~ *realised* their mood and trembled
- And said to all who were ~~assembled~~ *gathered* —
- Let us postpone consideration
- Of finer points like guilt. The nation

Scaffold – platform for execution

Councillor – adviser to the king

Mused – thought deeply

Restless – uneasy, impatient

Perceived – noticed, realised

Assembled – gathered

Postpone – delay

Consideration – careful thought

SUMMARY:

The king agreed to hang the arch, but before the execution, a councillor said it was dishonourable to punish something that had touched the king's head. The king agreed. Meanwhile, the crowd grew impatient, and sensing their mood, the king decided to forget about who was guilty and focus on giving the people what they wanted — a hanging.

The Tale of Melon City



- Wants a hanging. Hanged must be
- Someone, and that immediately.'
- The noose was set up somewhat high.
- Each man was measured by and by.
- But only one man was so tall
- He fitted. One man. That was all.
- He was the King. His Majesty
- Was therefore hanged by Royal Decree.

Noose – loop of rope used for hanging

By and by – eventually

Royal Decree – official order by the king

SUMMARY:

The king declared that someone must be hanged at once to satisfy the people. A noose was prepared, but it was high, and only one man was tall enough to fit it — the king himself. So, according to the law, the king was executed.

The Tale of Melon City

- ‘Thank Goodness we found someone,’ said
- The Ministers, ‘for if instead
- We had not, the unruly town
- Might well have turned against the Crown.’
- ‘Long live the King!’ the Ministers said.
- ‘Long live the King! The King is dead.’

Unruly – disorderly, difficult to control

Crown – symbol of monarchy/rule

SUMMARY:

The ministers were relieved that someone (the king) was found to be executed; otherwise, the angry crowd might have rebelled. They ironically shouted, “Long live the King!” even though he was dead.

QUESTION



Who did the king call for advice?

- 1 The councillor
- 2 The wisest man in the country ~~✗~~
- 3 The ministers
- 4 The architect again

QUESTION



Why did the wisest man say the arch should be punished?

- 1 It was weak
- 2 It knocked off the king's crown ✓✓
- 3 It was ugly
- 4 It was built too high

QUESTION



Who was tall enough to fit the noose?

- 1 The architect
- 2 A guard
- 3 The chief of builders
- 4 The king himself 

QUESTION



What happened to the king?

- 1 He was hanged by royal order //
- 2 He was crowned again
- 3 He was pardoned
- 4 He was exiled

The Tale of Melon City

- They pondered the dilemma; then,
- Being practical-minded men,
- Sent out the ^{messengers} heralds to proclaim
- (In His [former] Majesty's name):
- 'The next to pass the City Gate
- Will choose the ruler of our state,
- As is our custom. This will be
- Enforced with due ceremony.'

Pondered – thought carefully

Dilemma – a difficult choice between two bad options

Heralds – messengers making public announcements

Proclaim – announce formally

Due ceremony – proper formal process

SUMMARY:

The ministers now had to choose a new ruler. Following tradition, they announced that the next person to pass through the city gate would choose the ruler.

The Tale of Melon City



- A man passed by the City Gate.
- An idiot. The guards cried, 'Wait!
- Who is to be the King? Decide!'
- 'A melon,' the idiot replied.
- This was his standard answer to
- All questions. (He liked melons.) 'You
- Are now our King,' the Ministers said,
- Crowning a melon. Then they led
- (Carried) the Melon to the throne
- And reverently set it down.

Idiot – foolish person

Standard answer – usual reply

Reverently – with great respect

SUMMARY:

The first person to pass the gate was a fool whose answer to every question was “a melon” (because he liked melons). So the ministers declared a melon to be the new king and placed it on the throne with respect.

The Tale of Melon City



- This happened years and years ago.
- When now you ask the people, 'So —
- Your King appears to be a melon.
- How did this happen?', they say, 'Well, on
- Account of customary choice.
- If His Majesty rejoice
- In being a melon, that's OK
- With us, for who are we to say
- What he should be as long as he
- Leaves us in Peace and Liberty?'

On account of – because of

Customary – traditional

Rejoice – be happy

Liberty – freedom

SUMMARY:

The poet says this story took place long ago, but even today, the people are fine with having a melon as their ruler. They say they value personal freedom and peace more than the ruler's identity. If their king is happy being a melon and doesn't interfere in their lives, they are satisfied.

The Tale of Melon City

- The principles of laissez faire
- Seem to be well-established there.

Principles – basic rules or beliefs

Laissez-faire – policy of non-interference in people's lives

SUMMARY:

The poet ends by saying that the city follows the principle of laissez-faire — a political idea that means “let people do as they wish” without government interference.

QUESTION



Why were the ministers relieved after the king's execution?

- 1 The crowd was satisfied 
- 2 The arch was safe
- 3 The workmen were spared
- 4 They could choose a new king 

QUESTION



What was the idiot's choice for king?

- 1 A lion ✓
- 2 A melon ✓
- 3 A horse ✓
- 4 An elephant ✓

QUESTION



What is the people's attitude toward having a melon as king?

- 1 They are unhappy
- 2 They are angry
- 3 They are fine with it as long as they have peace and liberty ✓
- 4 They are ashamed

QUESTION



What political principle does the city follow?

- 1 Monarchy
- 2 Dictatorship
- 3 Socialism
- 4 Laissez-faire 

QUESTION



Narrate 'The Tale of Melon City' in your own words.

(H/W)

Answer:

Once upon a time, there reigned a calm king. He once wanted to build an arch that would eddy the people. The king's wish was quickly fulfilled, and a beautiful arch was built.

When the king rode down the thoroughfare, his crown fell from his head when it struck the arch, which was built too low. The king thought it was a disgrace to him and wanted to hang the perpetrator.

He commanded the chief of the builders to be hanged. The chief then stated that it was the builders' fault. The king then shifted the blame to the builders. The builders then cried that because the bricks were larger, the architect should be hanged. As a result, the architect was to be punished. The architect reminded the king that the king had made some changes to the design he had shown him. The blame was now back on the king.

He paused for a moment before ordering the soldiers to bring the wisest man in the country. They brought an old man who could barely see or hear, as the king had ordered. He proposed that the arch be hanged because it was the source of such disgrace, which was immediately implemented. Then one of the ministers disagreed, asking how they could shamelessly hang an arch. The king then reversed his decision and decided to deal with it his way.

They said the nation wanted someone hanged right away, so every man was measured, and only one man was tall enough to get trapped in the arch, and that man was the king. As a result, he was eventually hanged.

The country's people then desired a new king. They asked the first person to pass through the city gate, as is their custom. Regrettably, the individual was insane. When the soldiers questioned him about who should be the next king, he said, "Who should be the next king?" He said melon because he liked them the best. So a melon was finally crowned and placed on the throne.

QUESTION



What impression would you form of a state where the King was 'just and placid'?

Answer:

A state in which the king is just and peaceful will prosper if he is intelligent and strong as well. But in the state described in this poem, the king was so stupid that he convicted himself to death for no reason. He felt insecure about the actions he took and kept changing them. In such a state, no right decision can be made, and no situation can be handled properly.

QUESTION



How, according to you, can peace and liberty be maintained in a state?

Answer:

I believe that in a state, peace and liberty can be maintained,

1. By enforcing rules and making decisions that benefit the people. However, no law can be enacted that benefits everyone because what appears to be correct to one person may not be correct to another. As a result, laws should be drafted in such a way that they benefit the vast majority of people.
2. By disseminating a sense of unity among the people through all available means.

QUESTION



Suggest a few instances in the poem which highlight humour and irony.

Answer:

There are a few instances in the poem where humour and irony are highlighted.

They are as follows:

1. The king, who changed his mind after hearing each person he suspected of being a criminal.
2. The wise man's advice to hang the arch.
3. Finally, the madman's suggestion that they make a melon their king.

QUESTION



‘The Tale of Melon City’ has been narrated in verse form. This is a unique style which lends extra charm to an ancient tale. Find similar examples in your language. Share them in the class.

Answer:

Write your own answer.

→ Jm 82/10

Thank
You